

RETURN OF RANE RAJ

Pratapsingh Rane beats the anti-incumbency factor and returns to power, but his biggest challenge remains providing stability

Even in politics, there are exceptions to the rule. While anti-incumbency factor normally works against governments, Goa has proved to be an exception. After experiencing 13 tumultuous governments in the past 10 years, Goans have once again delivered a fractured mandate and the Congress has again managed to capture the spices to churn out another government.

By early evening on June 5, it was clear that the Congress would have reasons to celebrate as it took the lead by grabbing 16 seats out of the total 40 seats. The BJP won 14, the NCP three and others seven (see chart).

This election's moment of reckoning began as soon as the results were being declared. All elected MLAs rushed to their party offices with a list of probable supporters. After much horse-trading, the Congress called on Governor S.C. Jamir to stake claim to form the government. The combined tally of Congress and its pre-poll ally NCP stands at 19 while Congress chief ministerial candidate Pratapsingh Rane's son Vishwajeet Rane, who contested as an independent candidate, has extended unconditional support to his father's party. The party has now claimed the support of an independent candidate. It can also look up to two big names—Babush Monserrate and Churchill Alemao—both Congress rebels.

It's not surprising, however, as Goa has always been a bundle of political contradictions. After the recent Goa Regional Plan 2011 controversy when people accused the Congress government of selling off Goa to outsiders, the party put the blame on to its PWD minister Monserrate. So irked was Monserrate that he quit the govern-

ment and contested from the United Democratic Goan Party (UDGP). The Congress is now luring Monserrate.

Apart from regional parties showing surprising inclinations, this election saw a number of major upsets. Goa's most prominent politician and former chief minister Dr Wilfred D'Souza lost from Salegaon. Industries minister

Luizinho Faleiro suffered a humiliating loss against Alemao from Navelim and Assembly Speaker Fansisco Sardinha lost to a new face, Alexio Reginald, from Curtorim. Amid the setbacks, nine new faces have emerged in Goa politics and the most unexpected is the primary school teacher Gurudas Gauns from Pale constituency.

Goa may be the smallest state in the country, but the land of the beaches, which contributes most to India's tourism revenues, has a host of unresolved problems. The recent issue of the Regional Plan highlighted the fact that Goa has been put up for sale

and is being exploited ruthlessly. The existence of Russian land and drug mafia in the state has been completely ignored by the present Government even though the Opposition raised a hue and cry. The unchecked proliferation of unauthorised hotels and restaurants has also marred the state's infrastructure. As these issues played a major role in deciding the fate of political parties in Goa, the theme for the election was 'Save Goa'.

The BJP played the slogan to the hilt with its charismatic leader and former chief minister Manohar Parikkar leading from the front. But it was handicapped as the party contested only 33 of the 40 seats and did not have an alliance with other parties for the rest of the seats. Effectively, that meant that

the party had to win two out of every three seats contested to regain power, which, even die hard loyalists admitted, was an uphill task.

With political equations in Goa changing everyday, one has to wait and watch how long the new Government will last. The Goa victory has boosted the Congress's morale, after setbacks in Punjab, Uttarakhand and Uttar Pradesh. However, the 21st chief minister of Goa has many challenges ahead. The first and the most challenging: to make his Government last a full term. **by Prerana Thakurdesal**



BACK AGAIN: Son gives Rane a fresh lease

NEW EQUATION

PARTIES	2007	2002
CONGRESS	16	16
BJP	14	17
NCP	3	1
UDGP	1	3
MGP	2	2
SGF	2	NA
INDEPENDENTS	2	1

MGP: Maharashtrawadi Gomantak Party
SGF: Save Goa Front